The First 90 Days as a Church Deacon

A Biblical, Practical Guide to Serving the Pastor, Church, and Community

A 13-week field guide for humble, dependable service

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This guide is an original practical resource. It is not a substitute for your church's bylaws, safeguarding policy, pastoral direction, or applicable law. Scripture references invite readers to open a Bible and read each passage in context.

How to use this field guide

Each week gives a Scripture reading, a concrete service task, a worked situation, and a question for self-examination. Begin at week one even if you have served before: clarifying how this congregation makes decisions prevents duplicated or unauthorized work. Use the reference pages when a real request arrives.

A simple weekly rhythm

- Read the listed passages in context and pray before contacting anyone.
- Check the assigned care list and follow up on earlier promises.
- Complete one small service task that someone actually requested.
- Tell the correct person what was done and what remains open.
- Protect your household schedule so service remains sustainable.

A promise tracker can be as simple as date, person or request code, consent to share, next step, owner, deadline, and completion. Keep it within the church's approved system; this book should not contain personal medical or financial information.

Before day one: clarify your role

Ask for the current documents

Get bylaws, deacon ministry description, benevolence policy, child and vulnerable-adult safeguarding procedures, spending approvals, and the church's preferred contact channel.

Agree on decision rights

A deacon can notice needs and propose action. Only the authorized person or group can approve spending, speak for the church, share private information, or change policy.

Choose a safe record

Store just enough information to complete a task. Do not put diagnoses, account numbers, passwords, or unverified stories in a general meeting packet.

Name an escalation route

Know whom to call when a person is at risk, a report is required, an expense is urgent, or a concern involves a leader.

Thirteen weeks at a glance

Week 01 Listen before acting

Week 02 Know the biblical shape of service

Week 03 Build a prayer and contact rhythm

Week 04 Visit without taking over

Week 05 Guard privacy and trust

Week 06 Respond to a practical need

Week 07 Care for homebound members

Week 08 Handle conflict without becoming a judge

Week 09 Make meetings useful

Week 10 Support the pastor without overloading him

Week 11 Serve beyond the building

Week 12 Prepare a durable handoff

Week 13 Review the first 90 days

WEEK 01 / DAYS 1-7

Listen before acting

READ Acts 6:1-7; 1 Timothy 3:8-13

What to understand

Ask your pastor or chair how your congregation describes a deacon's work. Read the bylaws and any current ministry policies. Ask which responsibilities are shared with staff, committees, and other volunteers. A willing servant can still create confusion by promising help that someone else has already arranged.

This week in practice

Make a short map of who receives requests, who may approve spending, who may speak for the church, and who follows up. Keep your own first-week notes private. Meet one experienced deacon and ask for a concrete example of good follow-through. Ask a member where care is working well before asking where it has failed.

A situation to work through

A member says, “Can you tell the pastor that our class needs a new room?” Answer: “I can pass on the request and find out who makes that decision. I will tell you when I have an answer.” Record the request and date. Do not promise the room.

Seven small actions

- Day 1: Read Acts 6 and the church bylaws.
- Day 2: Ask the chair to explain approval paths.
- Day 3: Find the safeguarding contact.

- Day 4: Meet an experienced deacon.
- Day 5: List active requests and owners.
- Day 6: Follow up on one open promise.
- Day 7: Review who may speak for the church.

Ask yourself

Who has authority to assign this task? What can I promise today?

WEEK 02 / DAYS 8-14

Know the biblical shape of service

READ Mark 10:42-45; 1 Timothy 3:8-13

What to understand

The New Testament emphasizes tested character and trustworthy service. Do not treat the title as a supervisory rank or a reward for attendance. A deacon serves alongside other members, under the congregation's own governance. Acts 6 describes a distribution problem answered by selecting trusted servants; churches differ on how directly they connect that episode to the later office.

This week in practice

Read the passages slowly and list traits that would be visible at home, at work, and in church. Ask whether your conduct makes difficult conversations safer. Speak truthfully, decline gossip, handle money carefully, and keep your commitments. The daily test is often reliability in small matters.

A situation to work through

A friend asks what confidential issue the deacons discussed. Say: “We are working on it, but I cannot share another person's details. If the church needs to announce a decision, the right person will do that.”

Seven small actions

- Day 8: Read the deacon qualifications in context.
- Day 9: Ask where you need more consistency.
- Day 10: Practice a truthful response to a rumor.
- Day 11: Check your household commitments.
- Day 12: Serve in an unnoticed task.
- Day 13: Thank a fellow volunteer.
- Day 14: Reflect on character before title.

Ask yourself

Does this action serve a person or protect my position?

WEEK 03 / DAYS 15-21

Build a prayer and contact rhythm

READ James 5:13-16; Philippians 1:3-6

What to understand

Prayer can be steady without becoming a performance. Ask people what they are comfortable sharing and whether a name may be circulated. A request for prayer is not consent to broadcast a diagnosis. Establish a small list of people assigned to your care and a dependable time to make contact.

This week in practice

Schedule two brief check-ins, one pastor check-in, and time for your own family. Use a contact method each member prefers. If no answer comes, leave a simple message and try once later. Keep only the minimum facts needed for follow-through; avoid collecting sensitive detail in a shared spreadsheet.

A situation to work through

A member texts, “Please pray; I am at the hospital, but do not tell anyone yet.” Reply: “I will pray. I will keep this private. Would you like a call or help contacting a family member?”

Seven small actions

- Day 15: Ask two people for contact preferences.
- Day 16: Confirm consent before sharing prayer.
- Day 17: Make one brief care call.
- Day 18: Record the promised next step securely.
- Day 19: Give the pastor a useful update.
- Day 20: Check back on an older request.
- Day 21: Pray and protect a family rest period.

Ask yourself

Did I ask what can be shared, with whom, and when?

Visit without taking over

READ Matthew 25:35-40; Romans 12:15

What to understand

A useful visit begins with permission. Ask if a visit is welcome, whether the person has energy for it, and what time works. In a hospital, follow the facility's rules, hygiene requests, and visitor limits. A quiet presence can be more helpful than a long explanation of why suffering happened.

This week in practice

Introduce yourself to the patient and caregiver. Ask one open question, listen, and offer a short prayer only if wanted. Do not interpret symptoms, promise recovery, discuss medicines, or interfere with clinicians. Offer a concrete next action such as a meal, ride, or call through the church's normal process.

A situation to work through

If a caregiver says, “We are exhausted,” try: “That sounds hard. What task would make this week easier? I can check what help our church can arrange.” Then make exactly that follow-up.

Seven small actions

- Day 22: Ask permission for a visit.
- Day 23: Check facility rules or home access.
- Day 24: Prepare one open question.
- Day 25: Visit and listen without rushing.
- Day 26: Offer one practical next action.
- Day 27: Coordinate with the care team.

- Day 28: Check whether the action happened.

Ask yourself

Did I leave with a clear next action and the person's permission?

WEEK 05 / DAYS 29-35

Guard privacy and trust

READ Proverbs 11:13; Ephesians 4:25-32

What to understand

Ministry is not a reason to circulate private information. Discuss a care need only with the people who must act. Follow your church's child protection, safeguarding, and records policies. When someone describes abuse, threats, or immediate danger, use the church's safety process and applicable reporting requirements; do not promise secrecy that you cannot keep.

This week in practice

Separate a brief service record from personal impressions. Record the date, the help requested, the approved action, and who owns the next step. Avoid diagnoses, rumor, and speculation. Store notes securely and remove them when no longer needed under church policy.

A situation to work through

A volunteer asks why a family received help. Answer: “I cannot discuss their situation. I can explain how our church reviews requests generally.”

Seven small actions

- Day 29: Review the church privacy policy.

- Day 30: Remove unnecessary detail from notes.
- Day 31: Learn the abuse escalation path.
- Day 32: Practice a response to gossip.
- Day 33: Check access to shared records.
- Day 34: Ask whether consent covers a request.
- Day 35: Close a record that is no longer needed.

Ask yourself

Would I be comfortable if the person read what I recorded?

WEEK 06 / DAYS 36-42

Respond to a practical need

READ Galatians 6:2; 1 John 3:16-18

What to understand

Care requests deserve both compassion and a reliable process. Clarify the immediate need, timing, available community resources, and what the church may authorize. Financial help can involve fraud risk or conflicts of interest. Never personally promise church funds before the authorized decision maker has approved them.

This week in practice

Use one request owner and a date for follow-up. Ask what the person has already tried without making the conversation an interrogation. For rent, utilities, food, transportation, or repairs, connect the person to the appropriate ministry team and verify completion. If you cannot help, say so promptly and offer the next useful contact.

A situation to work through

A caller says the power will be cut off today. Ask for the deadline and the best callback number. Tell the designated benevolence contact immediately. Say, “I will call you by 3 p.m. with what I learn,” even if the answer may be no.

Seven small actions

- Day 36: Locate the benevolence policy.
- Day 37: Identify who approves an expense.
- Day 38: Practice documenting a deadline.
- Day 39: Identify one community resource.
- Day 40: Follow up with an applicant on time.
- Day 41: Check for unfinished requests.
- Day 42: Review one case without private detail.

Ask yourself

Is the next step both authorized and time bound?

WEEK 07 / DAYS 43-49

Care for homebound members

READ Hebrews 10:24-25; Romans 12:10-13

What to understand

Homebound people can be overlooked when ministry is built around attendance. Ask whether they prefer a visit, call, card, or help joining worship. Learn who their regular caregiver is, but do not assume that a caregiver may speak for them or receive their

information.

This week in practice

Coordinate with the care team so one person does not receive six visits in a day while another receives none for a month. Ask about access, mobility, hearing, and visit length. Include the person in church news they want to receive. Record only agreed follow-ups, such as a ride inquiry or a phone call after an appointment.

A situation to work through

At the door, ask: “Is this still a good time? I can stay ten minutes or come back later.” The member, not the visitor, sets the pace.

Seven small actions

- Day 43: Review the homebound contact list.
- Day 44: Ask each person about preferred contact.
- Day 45: Coordinate visits across the care team.
- Day 46: Make one short call or visit.
- Day 47: Share desired church news.
- Day 48: Check a caregiver need with permission.
- Day 49: Confirm next month's contact plan.

Ask yourself

Who has not been contacted this month?

WEEK 08 / DAYS 50-56

Handle conflict without becoming a judge

READ Matthew 18:15-17; James 1:19

What to understand

A deacon may hear competing stories. Resist the urge to adjudicate from a hallway conversation. Listen without endorsing rumors; ask what the person wants to happen and what direct conversation has already occurred. Follow the church's process for disputes and refer pastoral or safeguarding concerns promptly.

This week in practice

Separate facts you witnessed from what someone reported. State your limits: “I can listen and help identify the next appropriate conversation.” If two parties need a meeting, obtain consent and an appropriate facilitator. Do not promise that a conflict will be resolved quickly.

A situation to work through

Two members disagree about a ministry purchase. Summarize the shared goal, identify the policy and decision maker, and ask each to put a specific proposal in writing. A vote without clear facts is not a shortcut to peace.

Seven small actions

- Day 50: Read the conflict process.
- Day 51: Practice separating fact from report.
- Day 52: Listen without carrying a rumor.

- Day 53: Ask what outcome is sought.
- Day 54: Refer safety concerns promptly.
- Day 55: Help plan a direct conversation.
- Day 56: Check whether a next step is owned.

Ask yourself

Am I carrying a message that should be spoken directly?

WEEK 09 / DAYS 57-63

Make meetings useful

READ 1 Corinthians 14:40; Philippians 2:3-4

What to understand

Meetings should move care and service forward. Read the agenda, minutes, and relevant policy before arriving. Bring facts, a proposed action, a cost if applicable, and a named owner. Care stories should be anonymized when possible. Matters needing confidentiality belong in the proper setting, not a group text.

This week in practice

At the end of a meeting, restate decisions aloud: what was approved, who will act, by when, and who will communicate with the affected person. Send a concise record to the agreed channel. If no decision was made, record the next information needed and the date it will be gathered.

A situation to work through

Instead of “We should help the Smith family,” propose: “May I arrange two meals through the care team by Friday, after confirming the family wants them?”

Seven small actions

- Day 57: Read the agenda before meeting.
- Day 58: Gather facts for one open item.
- Day 59: Name the decision being requested.
- Day 60: Attend and listen for action owners.
- Day 61: Confirm decisions and deadlines.
- Day 62: Send an authorized concise update.
- Day 63: Close or carry forward each item.

Ask yourself

Will someone know what to do tomorrow morning?

WEEK 10 / DAYS 64-70

Support the pastor without overloading him

READ Hebrews 13:17; 1 Peter 5:2-3

What to understand

Ask the pastor what information is genuinely useful and what can be handled by the assigned team. Support includes truthful feedback, prayer, practical help, and healthy boundaries. It does not require agreement with every preference or using deacon meetings to manage the pastor by rumor.

This week in practice

Build a brief update rhythm: urgent concerns immediately, ordinary care needs at a predictable time, and completed work in a short summary. When offering criticism, state the observed

issue, its effect, and one constructive question. Respect the pastor's time and family commitments.

A situation to work through

Try: “Three families asked about transportation. The care team can coordinate volunteers. Are there pastoral concerns we should account for before we do that?”

Seven small actions

- Day 64: Ask the pastor's update preference.
- Day 65: Send only an urgent item urgently.
- Day 66: Summarize routine needs clearly.
- Day 67: Offer one practical help request.
- Day 68: Give constructive feedback privately.
- Day 69: Protect the pastor's family time.
- Day 70: Review the next update cadence.

Ask yourself

Am I bringing a decision, a fact, or just anxiety?

WEEK 11 / DAYS 71-77

Serve beyond the building

READ Matthew 5:13-16; Luke 10:25-37

What to understand

A church can notice local needs without pretending it can solve all of them. Learn what trusted local agencies already do. Ask ministry leaders where the congregation has capacity, and design service with the people affected rather than for them without

listening.

This week in practice

Choose one bounded opportunity: a food delivery partnership, a school supply request, a maintenance day, or a neighbor visit. Clarify insurance, safeguarding, transportation, funding, and the volunteer leader before announcing it. Count completed service, not only sign-ups.

A situation to work through

A community partner requests twenty volunteers next weekend. Say: “I will check our capacity and give you a firm number tomorrow.” An honest five is better than a promised twenty who do not arrive.

Seven small actions

- Day 71: Meet a trusted community partner.
- Day 72: Ask what help is already working.
- Day 73: Choose one bounded service idea.
- Day 74: Check policy and volunteer capacity.
- Day 75: Confirm owner, cost, and timing.
- Day 76: Serve with the affected people.
- Day 77: Measure completed help, not sign-ups.

Ask yourself

What existing relationship can we strengthen?

WEEK 12 / DAYS 78-84

Prepare a durable handoff

READ 2 Timothy 2:2; Colossians 3:23-24

What to understand

No ministry should depend on one person's memory. Make recurring tasks easy to understand without exposing private stories. A useful handoff tells a successor the purpose, decision path, contacts by role, normal timing, and where approved records are kept.

This week in practice

Review your active commitments: completed, waiting, or needing escalation. Verify with the person served that a new contact is welcome before transferring details. Ask whether the process can be simplified. A deacon who records the next step serves beyond the current term.

A situation to work through

A volunteer moves away while coordinating meal deliveries. Transfer only the household's current preferences and upcoming commitment through the authorized team, not months of private messages.

Seven small actions

- Day 78: List recurring tasks you own.
- Day 79: Find current instructions and contacts.
- Day 80: Close one old promise.
- Day 81: Transfer one task with permission.
- Day 82: Remove unneeded private messages.

- Day 83: Ask a successor to test the process.
- Day 84: Correct an unclear handoff.

Ask yourself

If I were absent for a month, what would stop?

WEEK 13 / DAYS 85-90

Review the first 90 days

READ Psalm 90:12; Philippians 1:9-11

What to understand

The goal of the first 90 days is a faithful rhythm, not an impressive list. Reflect on reliability, prayer, listening, family balance, respect for others' roles, and whether care requests receive a real response. Ask your pastor and one fellow deacon for a specific improvement.

This week in practice

Choose two practices to keep, one to stop, and one to learn. Close old promises or transfer them clearly. Thank volunteers by name with appropriate privacy. Set a sustainable calendar for the next quarter and leave room for unexpected needs.

A situation to work through

In the review meeting, say: “I followed up on eight assigned requests, missed one deadline, and changed my reminder process. I need help learning our benevolence policy.” That honesty is more useful than a polished report.

Seven small actions

- Day 85: List completed and open commitments.
- Day 86: Ask the pastor for one improvement.
- Day 87: Ask another deacon for feedback.
- Day 88: Choose two habits to keep.
- Day 89: Choose one task to stop or share.
- Day 90: Set next quarter's calendar.

Ask yourself

Who is better cared for because I followed through?

A ten-minute care call

Before

Check permission to call. Read only the current assignment. Find a private place to speak. Know the limits of what the church has authorized.

Open

“Hello, this is [name] from [church]. Is this a good time for a short check-in?” If the answer is no, offer a later time.

Listen

“How has this week been for you?” and “Is there one practical need you would like help with?” Do not rush to solve a problem you have not understood.

Confirm

“May I share this request with the care coordinator? What details may I include?” Repeat the agreed next step and deadline.

Close

“I will contact [role] today and update you by [time]. Would prayer be welcome?” After the call, record only the agreed service facts.

A visit in a hospital or home

Arrange the visit through the patient or caregiver. Check the hospital's current visitor rules. Use required infection-control measures. Be ready to leave promptly when a nurse, clinician, or family member needs the room. A person who is unwell may appreciate five attentive minutes more than forty minutes of conversation.

- Ask whether the visit is still wanted when you arrive.
- Listen before offering a Scripture passage, prayer, or practical help.
- Do not give medical interpretations or promise a particular outcome.
- Do not post photos or updates without explicit consent and church approval.
- Clarify the next action and who owns it.

If the person requests urgent medical help, use the facility staff or emergency service rather than trying to manage the problem yourself.

When a member is grieving

Loss changes what people can absorb. Offer a calm presence and a specific next action: a meal at an agreed time, a ride, help with

a service, or a later check-in. Ask who is coordinating the family's wishes. Do not assume they want visitors, a public prayer request, or a social media tribute.

A useful sentence

“I am sorry for your loss. I can sit with you, or I can help with a practical task. Which would serve you best today?”

A follow-through plan

The first week often brings attention. Consider a call several weeks later after visitors have gone home. Record the promised date privately and honor it. Coordinate with the pastor and care team so help does not become a parade of unplanned contacts.

Benevolence without confusion

Use your church's policy. A fair process identifies the request, deadline, documentation needed, decision maker, available resources, and how the outcome is communicated. It protects both the person asking and the people entrusted with church funds.

- Ask what is due, when, and how the bill can be verified.
- Explain the review process without suggesting that approval is certain.
- Avoid handling cash or private account information outside approved channels.
- Consider practical or community assistance when a payment is not possible.
- Confirm a decision and close the loop by the promised time.

Worked example

A family requests help with a $180 utility bill due Friday. On Tuesday, the deacon gathers the deadline and consent to contact the benevolence team. The authorized team reviews the policy and decides on Wednesday. The family is told the result that day, leaving time to call the utility company if needed.

Confidentiality decision tree

Is someone in immediate danger?

Use emergency services or the church's safeguarding route. Never promise absolute secrecy.

Is there a reporting duty or policy?

Follow applicable law and church procedure. Ask the designated safeguarding leader if unsure.

Does another person need details to act?

Ask what minimum facts they need and whether the person served has consented, where consent is appropriate.

Is this curiosity, gossip, or broad distribution?

Do not share. A prayer request can be general without naming private circumstances.

A meeting that ends with action

Before the meeting, read the agenda and send factual updates to the chair. During the meeting, identify the decision requested. After discussion, repeat the actual outcome: approved, declined, referred, or awaiting information. Record an owner and deadline for each open item.

Example action record

- Need: transportation for three appointments next month.
- Consent: member agreed to be contacted by the rides coordinator.
- Decision: care team may recruit vetted drivers under church policy.
- Owner: rides coordinator. Deadline: call the member by Thursday.
- Review: confirm the first ride happened before closing the item.

Avoid recording the member's unrelated medical history in the meeting minutes.

A difficult conversation

When someone complains about another leader, seek clarity without becoming a messenger for accusations. Ask what happened, what was directly observed, and whether the person has spoken with the other party. If there is a safety issue, use the safety route; otherwise, encourage the church's ordinary process for direct, respectful conversation.

Language that keeps the door open

- “I hear that this matters to you. What outcome are you hoping for?”
- “Which part did you witness yourself?”

- “Would you be willing to raise this with the person involved?”
- “I can help identify the appropriate next step, but I cannot promise the result.”

Do not conduct your own secret investigation. Document only what the right process requires.

A 90-day review page

Read your open commitments before answering these questions. If a promise remains unfinished, set a date and notify the person affected.

Where did I follow through reliably?

Write a short, specific answer in your own notes; protect people's private details.

Which request waited too long?

Write a short, specific answer in your own notes; protect people's private details.

What ministry am I doing that belongs to another person or team?

Write a short, specific answer in your own notes; protect people's private details.

What did I learn from someone whose need was easy to overlook?

Write a short, specific answer in your own notes; protect people's private details.

Which two habits will I keep next quarter?

Write a short, specific answer in your own notes; protect people's private details.

Scripture and source notes

Read Scripture in your preferred translation. This book refers to passages rather than reproducing copyrighted Bible text. Acts 6:1-7, 1 Timothy 3:8-13, Mark 10:42-45, Romans 12:10-15, James 1:19, and Galatians 6:2 are central starting points. Interpret them with your congregation's teaching and in their surrounding context.

The Baptist Faith and Message (2000), Article VI, describes a congregation's scriptural offices as pastor/elder/overseer and deacon. It also describes congregational accountability. Local church bylaws govern practical procedures; consult your own church leadership for those details.

Further reading

- Southern Baptist Convention, The Baptist Faith and Message 2000: bfm.sbc.net/bfm2000/
- LifeWay, Effective Pastor-Deacon Relationships: lifeway.com/articles/church-ministry-effective-deacon-pastor-relationships
- Bible passages: Acts 6:1-7 and 1 Timothy 3:8-13 in a trusted Bible edition.